Fit in my poems like a rhyme

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/53044081.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra)

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Family Fluff, Pregnancy, Childbirth, Angst with a Happy Ending, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Trans Adora (She-Ra), Transphobia/Deadnaming, Friends to Lovers, Parenthood, Useless Lesbians, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - Human, Catra and Adora are dumbasses, Slow Burn

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by the_deaf_pomegranate

Summary

Catra's resigned herself to singlehood and decides if she wants to be a mother anytime soon, she'll have to do it alone. What she doesn't expect is for her best friend - who's also the secret, unrequited love of her life - to make her the unbelievable offer of a sperm donation. Friends-to-lovers slow burn leading to family fluff.

"I could be your donor," Adora speaks so quietly and unexpectedly that Catra initially thinks she may have misheard, "You could do it all at home. Then you wouldn't have to wait."

"Adora, I wouldn't expect you to do that," Catra's so shocked that she surprises herself when she manages to respond at all, "Can you even do it, after the HRT?"

"Maybe," Adora shrugs, "We could try. We'd have to do it soon though, there's only three weeks until my surgery."

Notes

Brainrot alert: I got sick with a bad respiratory infection two weeks ago and all I could do was read fluffy family fics. The minute I could type again, I started on this. Hope you enjoy, and grateful for any kudos and comments you want to feed me (purely to aid my recovery, of course) ♡

See the end of the work for more notes

Catra stumbles through her front door and practically rips her heels off, half flopping on the floor to undo the straps at her ankles. She groans with relief when her feet stretch out flat on the smooth wood of the hallway, careful not to bash into the walls and wake her flatmate.

Her phone buzzes - it's probably Adora, bored in a hotel room and asking if she got home safe from her Hinge date - but it doesn't deter Catra from making a beeline for the fridge. She pulls out a box of apple slices and goes straight to her bedroom, peeling off her tight dress and exhaling heavily as she wriggles into far comfier pyjamas. All she's got to do is grab the jar of peanut butter she'd left on her bedside table the night before and she'll be all snuggled up.

When she finally checks her phone, she almost snorts at how predictable her best friend is - whenever Adora's travelling for work, she spends her lonely nights spamming Catra. This time, she's sent Catra a billion Instagram screenshots of the brunch food at a restaurant they're going to next week. She hits the phone button without even thinking.

"Dating is shitty," Catra grumbles to Adora as soon as she picks up, dunking an apple slice in the peanut butter and shoving it in her mouth, garbling her speech, "And I hate small plates. Why does everyone want to eat small plates instead of their own dinner? I don't wanna fucking share my overpriced teaspoon of hummus with anyone."

"Not a good match then?" Adora's voice comes through warm and sweet, and Catra has to remember to keep her fluttering heart under control, "You onto breadsticks and peanut butter now?"

Catra scoffs. "I told you I was being healthier," she pauses, imagining how Adora must be biting her lip to stop herself from laughing in disbelief, "I'm eating your stupid apple slices."

"They're good with peanut butter though. Right?" Adora teases.

Catra rolls her eyes; she never should have admitted she was following any of Adora's snack recommendations. "They're *fine*."

A yawn bleeds through the phone and Catra feels a little guilty when she notices it's past midnight on her alarm clock. Adora's in a time zone two hours ahead.

"Shit, I didn't see the time, 'Dor!" she exclaims, "You shouldn't answer so late if you're tired."

Adora chuckles lazily. "I don't mind, you can call me anytime."

"Go to bed, dummy. I'll see you at brunch when you're back."

Catra hangs up before Adora can object and stares at the ceiling. There's little that can stop the emptiness clouding her chest after yet another failed first date. Catra's pretty sure she's been on at least forty dates this year, and no-one she's gone out with has lasted more than a couple of meet-ups. There's always something about an app date that makes Catra feel transactional, like she's just looking to tick a load of boxes - or fill someone else's - rather than forging a genuine, organic connection. Besides, these days it seems like most people are looking for something different than she is; many of the folks she likes the look of are into open relationships or don't want kids, or even worse, are Geminis.

Catra thinks back to the last relationship she had, now nearly five years ago. She'd told herself after that messy breakup that if she hadn't found a partner by thirty-five, she should probably just give up. Catra sighs, pulling up Instagram mindlessly. It seems like there's countless posts of her old school friends getting married or having babies in her hometown, which she forces herself to like (though she only comments 'congratulations' on someone's PhD graduation).

It's easier for them back home, she tells herself, repeating the reassurances Adora has given her many times before, *a lot of things take longer if you're queer.*

It doesn’t take long for her doomscroll to be interrupted by an ad for a sperm bank. Catra grumbles, muttering that she shouldn’t have liked so many damn baby photos. She knows she’s going to be hit with pregnancy test ads for weeks if she watches it through to the end but she does it anyway. She’s thirty-four, uncomfortably close to the arbitrary deadline she’d given herself to get her love life together. The chances of her meeting someone and having a kid while she’s still fertile seem slimmer than ever; and for the first time, it really urgently feels like a *now* problem.

Catra watches the cryobank video again and clicks through to the website. There’s so much information about how it all works, from donor screening to artificial insemination, and the more she reads, the more confident Catra gets that she could do motherhood alone if she had to. It isn’t the lifestyle she ever thought she’d pick, but what point was there waiting for a partner when she’d likely have to use donor sperm anyway? In the middle of the night, it seems practically foolish for Catra to pass the opportunity up.

She throws her phone onto the pillows, figuring it’s something to research properly in the morning. Yet it doesn’t stop Catra from thinking about the kind of donor she’d pick as she drifts off to sleep: smart, athletic, kind, musical, and tall enough to save her offspring from a future of balancing on stepladders and kitchen countertops while cooking. Basically, she realises, *Adora*.

For a moment Catra entertains the idea, but dismisses it quickly. Adora only has six weeks until her long-awaited bottom surgery. The last thing Catra would ever do is risk dredging up dysphoric thoughts at this time. Her friend deserves so much better than that. Catra - if she really is bold enough to do this - would just have to settle for the next best thing.

It only takes twenty minutes for Catra to crack when Adora spends the first part of their hangout trying to figure out why she's in such a weird mood.

"Was the date last week really that bad?" Adora asks for the third time, her brow furrowing in concern.

Catra watches how Adora leans a little forward and her eyes focus so singularly on her. There's few people who make her feel this important, and that's always been the problem. Catra's been in love with Adora since forever but she can't risk losing her closest friend. It's not like she has that many spare.

"No," Catra sighs and spears a piece of syrup-drenched pancake on her fork, deciding she'd rather not spend the rest of the morning evading Adora's questions, "I think I just decided on something kind of big."

"Something big?" Adora's intrigued, "Did you finally submit your LPC application?"

Catra cringes. As if she needs another reminder of how frequently she's failed to get over that particular hurdle - with every year that passes in her paralegal job, she's convinced herself even more that she hasn't got a chance of qualifying to become a solicitor, despite her boss' encouragement.

"No. I…" *Fuck, this is harder to admit than I thought,* "I think I'm going to have a kid."

Adora's eyes widen and they dip down to the empty cocktail glasses on their table, her hand darting out to take Catra's. Her voice is hushed, overly sensitive, "Are you pregnant? How long have you known?"

"I'm not pregnant yet!" Catra rushes to clarify. She doesn't want Adora thinking she's had a million one night stands during her recent string of dates, or that she'd be downing mimosas if she actually was knocked up. The wrinkle between Adora's eyebrows deepens with confusion and Catra sighs heavily, "I'm just tired of

waiting for my person to come along to do it. Though donor sperm and IUI are so expensive, I'm probably going to have to save for another year or two just to give it a shot."

There's a beat of silence between them and Catra suddenly isn't confident that she's made the right choice discussing this with Adora. She looks up at her friend unsurely and finds her rolling her shoulders back, a pensive expression forming on her face.

"What?" Catra narrows her eyes and tips the dregs of her drink into her mouth, "That's a dangerous amount of thinking you're doing there."

"I could be your donor," Adora speaks so quietly and unexpectedly that Catra initially thinks she may have misheard, "You could do it all at home. Then it would be free. You wouldn't have to wait."

"Adora, I wouldn't expect you to do that," Catra's so shocked that she surprises herself when she manages to respond at all, "Can you even do it, after the HRT?"

"Maybe," Adora shrugs, "We could try. We'd have to do it soon though, there's only three weeks until my surgery."

It's definitely not an option on the table but Catra's skin flushes at the idea of having sex with Adora anyway. She's certainly thought about it plenty of times before. Still, if it ever did happen, Catra has to know Adora feels the same way that she does. She doesn't want to wonder afterwards if it means anything.

"Even so," Catra fights to suppress her thoughts, determined not to have the conversation sullied by her inappropriate fantasies, "It wouldn't be upsetting for you to do it?"

"Upsetting?" Adora looks truly puzzled, "It would be amazing to do this for you! You'd be the best mum, Catra."

"You think?" Catra blushes. Deep down, there's a lot of reasons why she assumes many folks would disagree. She's difficult.

Acerbic. Her bite's just as loud as her bark when she's pushed into a corner. Adora squeezes her hand.

"I *know.* "

Quiet settles between them again as Adora picks up a piece of avocado toast with her fingers and dips it into a pool of egg yolk on her plate.

"I actually froze some of my sperm before I started transitioning, you know. Just in case."

"You did?"

"It's probably a waste of money," Adora admits, her eyes downcast, "I can't imagine anyone actually wanting to date me, let alone have a family…"

"Adora, are you kidding me?" Catra balks, desperate to reassure her friend, "Girls are lining up around the block to date you! You're gorgeous, and you don't have a completely terrible personality. Anyone would be lucky to find their happily ever after with you."

It's a relief when Adora smiles at Catra shyly. It's a good feeling to be able to tell Adora what she really thinks without giving away the true nature of her desire.

"You just need to give someone a chance, 'Dor."

Adora holds Catra's gaze for a second before she goes back to her plate. There's a tenderness to the rest of their morning that Catra hasn't felt in years. If she didn't know better, she'd think she was getting soft.

It makes it even harder to face reality the next day and call Adora to let her off the hook. Catra can't let her friend donate to her. It's too much to possibly ask. Yet Adora's insistent that she wants to help while she still can, and her enthusiasm infects Catra with a hope that she hasn't felt since deciding she was willing to parent

alone. Once they figure out when she'll ovulate and circle the dates in their diaries, Catra can't ignore the excitement that starts to simmer in her gut.

"Are you sure you're comfortable?" Catra fluffs the pillows behind Adora again, stretching over the bed to smooth out her duvet.

"Yes, thank you," Adora grins, though Catra can tell she's starting to get a little annoyed by her constant faffing, "Will you sit down and watch the movie with me now?"

Catra rolls her eyes and scrambles under the covers next to Adora, careful not to jostle the bed too much. It's been two weeks since her surgery and Catra has come over every day after work to help her, often sleeping overnight on the sofa. There's purpling bags under her eyes, and even Bow admitted she looks like shit when they catch each other between Adora shifts. Still, Catra would rather let her whole body go to ruin than let Adora cope on her own for a second.

"Kill me for trying not to break your new pussy."

"I think there's better ways of breaking my pussy than letting me slump a little in bed," Adora smirks, digging her finger into Catra's side.

"Ow," Catra yelps, and though she doesn't dare poke Adora back, she loves to notice the glow of pride and comfort that rises in Adora when they mention her new vulva, even in jest, "You're an asshole."

"An asshole that wants to watch *Carrie,*" Adora agrees, finally pressing play on the TV that's been set up at the foot of her bed.

Catra burrows deeper into the pillows, internally congratulating herself on how perfectly she's positioned them. It isn't long until Adora's arm is around her, and she lets her head roll against her friend's muscular inner bicep. She's so comfortable that she struggles to stay awake for most of the film.

This doesn't mean anything, Catra reminds herself, *Adora's just being nice because I'm tired and I've been looking after her.*

"This is better than Fright Night at the Waste," Adora murmurs as the film begins to reach its climax, "Remind me why we ever went out on Halloween?

"Sexy nurses," Catra mumbles, though the more she watches buckets of blood descend on screen, the more her mind whites out. She lets the date sink in, counting back the weeks. She's been so distracted caring for her friend, she hasn't kept track of herself at all.

"It's October 31st." Catra doesn't realise she's spoken out loud until Adora peers at her curiously.

"Yes…?"

Catra turns to Adora, her face slack, "I'm a week and a half late."

"*Catra*," Adora squeezes her hard, "You have to do a test."

"It's probably just stress," Catra insists, fighting against the quickening of her pulse as she struggles not to get her hopes up, "I've been running around like mad between here and work, and I've missed periods before when I'm exhausted. I'd know if I were pregnant, right?"

"I don't know," Adora blinks, her voice gentle, "Haven't people, like, found out when they're giving birth?"

"Fuck," Catra leans forward, head in her hands, "Am I already a shitty mother? I completely lost track of the calendar with everything going on."

“No, you’re not,” Adora affirms, “But you do need to test. I have a couple in the bathroom.”

“What?” Catra can tell her voice is tinny, her throat already tight with nerves.

“It was just in case you wanted me there,” Adora shifts anxiously, her eyes avoiding Catra’s pupils, “I didn’t want to waste time trying to find them on the way to yours.”

“Okay.” Catra whispers, hauling herself out of bed carefully. Her hands wobble as she opens up Adora’s bathroom cabinet. She’s done this so many times over the past fortnight looking after Adora; she can’t believe she’d missed the two test boxes stacked on the top shelf.

Catra fumbles to open the first one, her chest heaving.

“Hey,” Catra looks up to find Adora wincing in the doorway, stepping towards her gingerly, “You’ve got this, okay?”

“Why are you up, dummy?” Catra tries not to cry, but her voice shudders too much for plausible deniability.

“I’m fine,” Adora reaches Catra and presses her lips to her forehead. They’ve been close like this before, but the energy feels so charged that Catra freezes before she softens into Adora’s embrace, “Are you ready?”

Catra nods, letting Adora take the box from her hands and open it properly for her. She takes the test and ambles to the toilet, forcing herself to focus on the instructions Adora reads out. She doesn’t know what to do with herself as they wait for the result to appear; Adora’s terrible attempt at distracting her with puns goes miles over her head. When the timer goes off on Adora’s phone, Catra gulps. It takes everything she has to look at the test.

“Catra?” Adora sounds almost as nervous as she is, “What does it say?”

Catra raises her head to Adora, finally letting her unshed tears go. “It actually worked.”

“You’re pregnant?” Adora gasps, pushing herself slowly towards Catra.

“I’m pregnant,” Catra nods rapidly and covers her mouth with her hand, a sob bursting from her chest, “Adora, I don’t know how to thank you.”

“You don’t need to, Cat,” Adora says gently, and Catra believes her, “Save it until the tables turn and it’s me taking care of your pregnant ass.”

“I don’t expect that, not after everything you’ve already done.”

Catra’s sure Adora looks dejected for a moment, but it clears fast and Adora plasters a smile on her face. In other circumstances, Catra knows she’d dig into that properly but her mind is racing at throttleneck speed. Unbelievably - as long as everything goes the way she hopes - she’ll have a baby to celebrate Halloween with next year.

Since she’s gotten back on her feet, Adora’s been blown away by the harmony that has settled over her. There’s an unprecedented ease that thrums through her as she wakes each day; it surprises her so much more than she expected, even after so many years of saving for her surgery. Her closeness to her friends has grown even further than she thought possible too. She knew that Bow, Glimmer and Catra would do their best to look after her, but it’s altogether different to seeing it happen. She’d felt important - precious, even - when they poured her countless glasses of water or brought her bowls of steaming soup.

Adora’s determined not to take it for granted. She schedules more time than ever with her friends when she’s not working - and even if she spends most of her evenings holding Catra’s hair back while she pukes, Adora’s gratitude doesn’t waver a bit. If anything, she has to be told not to feel so indebted, or at least, in Catra’s words, to ‘stop being so fucking obvious about it’.

Still, Adora’s under no illusions that Catra’s secretly relieved to have her around. When Catra invites her to her first ultrasound at twelve weeks, Adora can't quash the excitement she feels. It might be second-hand anticipation, but she's just as jittery as Catra when she picks her up to drive to the hospital.

“Are you sure you’re really okay with this?” Catra speaks breezily as they walk through the hospital corridors, though Adora knows that the tight hold Catra has on her hand is proof that she’s terrified of a negative answer.

“Bit late for that now,” Adora jokes, but when Catra doesn’t even roll her eyes, she knows she needs reassurance. She stops them in the middle of the corridor, turning to face Catra in full, “I wanted to do this, Catra. You didn’t make me.”

Catra nods, her grip on Adora’s hand tightening. Adora studies her; Catra’s usually so sure of herself, and it’s strange watching this new swirl of emotions playing out. She knows Catra doesn’t regret going ahead with her pregnancy - every day, Adora gets a link to some overpriced baby equipment she’s never heard of, or a screenshot of what fruit the baby is apparently now the same size as - but there’s something Catra isn’t saying that makes her waver in the face of Adora’s continued support.

“Come on,” Adora says, bringing them back to Earth and nudging Catra past the signs to the maternity unit, “We don’t want to be late meeting your little one.”

Perhaps they should have expected it, arriving hand-in-hand, but the minute they get to the ward, almost everyone mistakes Adora for Catra’s partner. It’s almost embarrassing, the number of times

one of them has to correct a midwife or fellow patient. Yet it isn't until Catra winces at cold jelly plopping onto her skin that her friend finally cracks.

"You make such a lovely couple, dearies," Catra's wizened obstetrician, Dr. Razz, muses, her ultrasound wand pressed to Catra's lower abdomen, "It's always nice when you come to parenthood at exactly the right time with the right person. Not too early and not too late..."

Razz doesn't get to continue her rambling. Catra practically erupts with a growl, her face reddening with every passing second, "I'm single! And yes, I'm doing this on my own! We're not a couple and we're never going to be one, so could everyone just fucking listen and stop assuming that we are?"

For a second the room freezes, and for the first time in a while, Adora's newfound confidence falters a little.

See? She's never going to be interested in you. Not even now.

And then there's a firm whoosh of a heartbeat filling the empty space, pushing against the tepid air. Catra and Adora gasp simultaneously, their eyes widening when Dr. Razz twists the ultrasound screen and shows them Catra's baby for the first time.

"Strong and healthy heartbeat," Razz says airily, breezing straight past Catra's outburst, "They'll be baking pies in no time."

"It looks like a real baby," Catra says bluntly, unable to take her eyes off the screen.

"What were you expecting?" Adora can't stop laughter from bubbling up her chest, "A fish?"

"I don't know. Maybe."

It feels like a miracle when they finally make it out of the examination room alive, a slew of grainy ultrasound photos in Catra's hand. Catra seems completely unlike her normal self,

hyper focused on the images and hardly hearing anything Adora has to say. It's heartwarming enough to see Catra so enamoured that Adora almost asks if she can take one, though she bites her lip. There's bigger fish she has to fry and Adora's more resolute that she has to address them.

"Hey, Cat? Can we talk for a second?" Adora hates how her speech quivers a little.

Catra startles as if she's only just remembering anyone else is with her, before her face twists with embarrassment. "I'm sorry if today's been a little intense. I didn't think everyone would assume you're my…" Catra's voice trails off, her lips unwilling to shape around the word 'wife', and Adora feels like she could shatter, "...But I'm so grateful you came with me. Really."

Adora shakes her head quickly to alleviate Catra's fears. "I wanted to be here. I just think we need to get on the same page about a couple of things before they become problems."

Catra stares at Adora, clearly a little shaken. There's a lot of conversations they should have had before they got themselves into this, and Adora feels like an idiot that she'd waved off so many of those that Catra had tried to start. Her previous insistence that they could figure things out as they come seems suddenly immature.

"Alright," Catra replies hesitantly, "What problems?"

Adora looks Catra up and down before she forces herself to forge ahead. Catra's so slight that her belly already rounds a little under her t-shirt, pushing against the buckle of her jeans. "You're already starting to show, Cat. People will start asking questions soon."

"Well, it isn't any of their business," Catra rebuts defensively, her mind sharpening in seconds, "It's *my* baby, not theirs."

Adora ignores the pang in her chest when Catra says that, reaching up to scratch the back of her neck. It's her nervous tic -

Catra will see it immediately - but she's thought long and hard enough about saying this that she wants to get it right.

"I know. I just wanted to tell you that I'm okay being known as the donor if you don't want to keep it a secret," Adora confesses.

Catra blanches and Adora thinks another wave of morning sickness must have hit her, but she only peers at Adora more closely, her hand coming up to grip Adora's wrist.

"That's a big thing, Adora," Catra says quietly, "You'll be outed to anyone who finds out in the future. Is that really what you're comfortable with?"

"I'm not ashamed of who I am," Adora's surprised by the strength and speed of her own conviction, and it emboldens her to hover her palm near the slope of Catra's abdomen, silently waiting for permission to touch, "I don't want your baby to be either."

Catra steps closer to Adora and forces Adora's hand into contact with her stomach. Catra puts a firm palm over it and adds pressure to the touch, reaching up to cradle Adora's jaw in her other hand. It's another show of intimacy that Adora doesn't quite know how to read anymore.

"They won't be. I promise. They'll love you for exactly who you are, just like I do."

"Are you serious?" Glimmer exclaims as soon as the news escapes Adora's lips, "She's pregnant? Why would you…? What were you thinking?"

Adora shrinks in her chair at Bow and Glimmer's dining table. This isn't going how she thought it would.

“Glimmer,” Bow pats his wife’s arm soothingly, “I’m not sure this is helpful.”

“Helpful?” Glimmer fumes, “Adora, what exactly do you think is going to happen here? You have a kid together and Catra magically falls in love with you?”

“We’re not having it together. The baby’s hers.” Adora can’t help but be defensive even though Glimmer’s accusation rings a little close to home.

Glimmer pushes back from the table and starts to pace up and down the kitchen. Bow tilts his head apologetically at Adora, knowing full well there’s no way forward except to let his wife blow off all her steam. Adora’s leg jiggles and she bites her lip to stop it from wobbling. This really isn’t the reaction she was hoping to get from her closest friends. Maybe she was naive but she honestly thought they’d be happy for Catra more than anything else.

Her mind begins to spiral the longer Glimmer paces; Adora starts to wonder if she’s done something entirely unethical by not being honest with Catra about her feelings. It isn’t a minefield she wants to navigate whatsoever.

“I only wanted to help,” Adora blurts out when she can’t bear it anymore, “That’s all this is. Catra needed something and I could give it to her. Simple.”

Glimmer exhales heavily, sinking back into her seat. “Look, ‘Dor. It’s an amazing gift, it really is. I’m just worried you’re not protecting yourself with this. Have you thought about what it’s gonna feel like when Catra’s kid is growing up and you know you’re their parent? Are you really going to be okay with that?”

Adora grips the edges of her chair until her knuckles go white. “I thought it through, Glim. I’m not some lovesick idiot who can’t make adult choices.”

She watches as Glimmer and Bow catch each other's eyes, some kind of silent communication taking place that she's not privy to. Finally, they look back at her and Glimmer slumps in her chair.

"I'm not so sure about the lovesick part, Adora."

"Wow, Wildcat," Scorpia's eyes seem to sparkle as she wells up, the ultrasound photo held in her hands, "Congratulations! This is why you've been so unwell?"

Catra smiles gratefully at her flatmate and nods. She's heard from Adora that not everyone has reacted so well to the news of her pregnancy, though she hasn't told Scorpia the kicker yet.

"There's more," she says nervously.

"It's not twins, is it?" Scorpia's excitement grows bigger and anticipation builds in Catra's gut.

"No, no! At least I hope not," Catra can't imagine having to wrangle two newborns on her own, even if Scorpia remains this enthusiastic after she gives birth; she inhales deeply, hoping that Scorpia takes the next part better, "I didn't use an anonymous donor. It was Adora, just before her surgery."

"Oh!" Scorpia practically chokes on thin air, "But you… You're-!"

"Totally in love with her?" Catra cringes, unable to stop tears from rolling down her cheeks. She hates how emotional she always is these days, how her hormones paint every feeling on her sleeve, "Yeah, I know."

"Did something happen…? Was it an accident?" Scorpia sounds scandalised, her head cocking to the side.

“God, no! She offered to donate. At first I said no but the more I thought about it, the more I couldn’t deny she was the perfect donor,” Catra’s hand flies to her stomach protectively. She’s been so careful not to do this around anyone that it’s a huge relief to finally give into instinct, “She’s got all the traits anyone could want for their kid. It was the best start I could give them.”

“Well. I know Adora’s always been important to you,” Scorpia reaches out and grips Catra’s other hand, “I trust you, Wildcat. And if this is what you want, then I’m all onboard.”

“Thank you,” Catra’s so grateful it makes her burst into tears all over again.

“Just be careful, okay?” Scorpia says, “There’s a lot more at stake now than before.”

Scorpia’s words sink into Catra’s ears slowly and heavily. She’s pleased there’s another person in her corner now, but she wishes Scorpia hadn’t planted any seeds of doubt in her head.

Adora races up the building stairs and knocks on Catra’s front door, her knuckles knocking a triple tap on the wood. She usually goes straight home to crash after an overnight flight but after the mess she’s found herself in, her flat is the last place she wants to go.

“Adora?” Catra’s bleary-eyed when she opens the door, and it startles Adora after working abroad for the past eight weeks to see how much her bump now strains against her t-shirt. She’s received countless mirror selfies from Catra while away, but they apparently didn’t prepare Adora for seeing Catra in person at all, “I didn’t think you’d be home yet, it’s barely six am.”

“Can I come in?” Adora’s voice is tight, close to tears, “I didn’t know where else to go.”

Catra seems to wake quickly at those words, her focus on Adora sharpening. She pulls Adora into her home, leading her to the sofa in the living room. There’s legal textbooks strewn all over the coffee table and Adora wonders if Catra’s finally decided to qualify as a solicitor. They sit close enough for their knees to press together; Catra leans forward to take her hand and Adora’s mind swims as she figures out how to explain everything.

“What’s going on?” Catra asks worriedly, “I’ve never seen you like this before.”

Adora takes in how fearful Catra looks and it makes her feel guilty. The last thing her friend needs when she’s six months pregnant is taking on all of Adora’s shit.

“I shouldn’t have come. It’s too much.”

“It’s never too much,” Catra stops Adora from standing up and pulls her back into place firmly, her initial agitation morphing into stubbornness, “Tell me.”

Adora hates admitting to vulnerability, especially when she’s certain that those around her need her to be strong. Yet the determined look on Catra’s face is difficult to resist. How easy would it be to let her listen, and to feel less alone? She decides to take a leap.

“My landlord’s evicting me,” Adora confesses, “I’ve got to be out by the end of the week. I’m lucky it wasn’t any sooner, I wouldn’t have gotten home in time to sort it.”

“What? You’ve been there for years! Did you miss a payment?” Catra’s almost as shocked as Adora was when she received the email last night.

“No. He says it’s because I haven’t been around enough to tend the garden. Upkeep bullshit. But my neighbour called me

yesterday apologising because she mentioned my surgery to him. She didn't know I hadn't told him I'm trans."

Catra's blood boils immediately. "That fucker!" she spits, "You have to fight this, Adora. It's illegal!"

"I can't prove anything, Cat," Adora hangs her head, "I've just got to find somewhere else."

Catra stands, pacing in circles as she thinks things through. "You can't let him get away with this, it's your home! Let me ask my boss if she can help. Maybe she'll take you on pro bono."

Adora stands up and grabs Catra's wrists to stop her from spiralling any further. She knows what Catra's like when she's got a bee in her bonnet, and the last thing Adora wants is to cause her unnecessary stress. If she started any legal proceedings, they'd run straight through Catra's due date, right when she's going to need Adora's support the most.

"I don't *want* to, Catra. It could drag on for months, and I'd rather be focused on other things," Adora hopes Catra understands what she's trying to say, what she's too scared to verbalise explicitly, "Please listen to me. I just want to move on."

Catra finally gives in.

"Okay," she pulls Adora into a hug, pressing her cheek into Adora's shoulder, "We'll figure out somewhere new for you. No lawyers."

Adora inhales Catra's scent, her heart rate finally beginning to slow. It's been a nightmarish couple of days waiting to get back on home soil, but everything feels better with Catra in her arms. She hugs her friend even tighter; it's a shock when the slightest nudge rolls into Adora's hip and a pained breath rushes into her ear.

"Are you okay?" Adora panics, stepping back to watch Catra rub the side of her bump.

“They’re just kicking,” Catra laughs breathlessly, drawing lazy circles with her fingers on her skin, “That’s what it feels like.”

She grabs at Adora’s hand and slips it under her shirt, pressing Adora’s palm onto her skin. “Can you feel them? They’re not normally so active this early but I think they want to say hello.”

Adora gasps when she feels movement again, her shock quickly thawing into a giggle. “This is wild. They’re so strong!”

“What did you expect?” Catra raises an eyebrow, “You’re a footballer, I knew what I was signing up for.”

Adora hugs Catra again and kisses her cheek. Adora’s spent more than a decade figuring out how to stop being in love with Catra but if this is the only way she can have her, Adora knows she’ll keep saying yes, over and over again. She’ll always remember how the hairs on the back of her neck stood up when Catra walked into their university bar like she owned it and pushed through rows of rowdy students - including Adora and her fellow footballers - to get her beer without waiting.

“You should go back to bed,” she says finally, already regretting the loss of holding Catra in her arms before they break apart, “It’s not like I’m going to find anywhere new to live at this hour.”

“Actually…” Catra starts, though she shakes her head quickly, “No. It isn’t fair on you.”

“What?”

Catra peeks at her through squinted eyes, clearly weighing up whether to express her thoughts or not. Finally, she gives in, a hefty sigh punctuating her words.

“Well, you know I told you Scorpia’s moving in with her girlfriend at the end of the month?” Adora nods at Catra’s question, “I still haven’t found anyone to take her room. Turns out the whole imminent newborn thing is kind of a turn-off.”

“Are you suggesting I move in with you?”

“No, not really,” Catra scoffs, though Adora can see right through her bullshit. Catra’s hopeful but she’ll never admit it, not when she thinks Adora can do better, “You can’t live here with a screaming baby. It’s too much.”

Adora reads Catra’s subtext easily: *I’m too much.* In seconds, she runs through the benefits of living with Catra besides the obvious of getting to *live with Catra* . Splitting the rent is much cheaper than renting somewhere on her own again, and Catra’s place is way closer to Bow and Glimmer’s house than she’d likely be able to afford. It’s easier than it should be to convince herself they can kill two birds with one stone and come out the other side unscathed.

“It works for me,” Adora says decisively.

“What?” Catra double-takes.

“Yep,” Adora pops her ‘p’, “I’ve always loved your flat. I’ll just ask Bow and Glimmer if I can crash with them until Scorpia moves out.”

“You really don’t have to do this,” Catra wraps her arms around herself, “I’ll find someone eventually. It’s just going to take a little longer than usual.”

“You’re the one doing me a favour, Cat,” Adora replies sincerely, “I need a place to live, you need someone to help pay the mortgage. It’s perfect.”

A bashful grin spreads across Catra’s face and Adora’s heart swells with pleasure at the knowledge that she’s the reason for it.

“You can just crash in my room for now if you want,” Catra sounds shy, shyer than Adora’s heard for a while, “I know I’m kinda huge now but the bed’s a king.”

“Are you sure? I can take the sofa.” Adora offers.

“It’s fine. I’d feel too guilty about you fucking up your back if you sleep there. Besides,” Catra smirks, her tone turning playful, “You already got me pregnant.”

“Okay,” Adora accepts, her skin flushing.

“Okay.” Catra repeats, before she turns and makes her way to the bedroom, “You coming? You look like shit.”

Adora scurries after her. Catra slips into bed and closes her eyes to give Adora privacy as she strips to her underwear and vest. When Adora joins her, they instinctively shuffle next to each other like magnets, their shoulders and hips fused together. Adora’s whole being melts when she realises that her body doesn’t make her feel out of place anymore. She’s never laid in another person’s bed without tension rippling through her before, not even when she had sleepovers with Glimmer and Bow in their college days. If she wasn’t so distracted by Catra’s gentle exhales next to her, Adora could easily cry with gratitude from the realisation.

When Catra rolls sideways and flings an arm across her with a sigh of relief, Adora realises what’s really in it for the other woman. Her entire body is being repurposed as a human pregnancy pillow. Yet Adora learns quickly that shouldering the extra weight comforts her as much as it soothes Catra. Within minutes, they’re both fast asleep.

Scorpia’s hardly around for the first two weeks Adora moves in though it isn’t until they’re officially living alone that things get far more domestic. Catra can recite a list of the old-married-couple habits they’ve developed, from cooking meals together to pooling laundry, and working shea butter into Adora’s back tattoos after she showers. It doesn’t take much longer for Catra to realise her list doesn’t even include Adora’s dedication to easing her

pregnancy; there's hardly been a night that Adora hasn't massaged Catra's swollen feet when she kicks her heels off after work, or a craving that Adora hasn't gone shopping to satisfy. All she can do is try her best not to read anything into the depth of Adora's care.

If she knew better, Catra wouldn't have let Adora stay in her bed once Scorpia's room freed up. She's got a real pregnancy pillow to wrap around in the night and ease her back pain, though they both pretend she sleeps better when Adora slots her muscular leg between Catra's thighs and balances out her hips.

After four weeks of bed-sharing, Catra's guard slips she sheimagines what it would be like if she was actually having her baby *with* Adora. She's been committed for over seven months to raising her child alone, and Catra knows it won't do her any good to fantasise about things being different. Yet when she wakes every night and finds Adora's fingers resting on the curve of her belly, Catra has to force herself to dismiss the tingle that pinches at her heart.

On the eve of Catra's third trimester, they're huddled on the sofa. Adora starts playing Mozart for the fifth night in a row.

"What gives with this shit, dude?" Catra whinges, poking Adora's shoulder. She's starting to regret letting Adora pair her phone with the sound system, "You haven't listened to classical music for years but you've been putting it on for weeks!"

Adora goes pink, angling her phone towards Catra. "It's a pregnancy playlist," Adora admits, clearly embarrassed, "It's supposed to be good for the baby."

"Well, it's horrible for me! I hate it!" Catra lunges for Adora's phone but she moves it out of Catra's reach, "Shouldn't a pregnancy playlist involve music pregnant people actually want to listen to?"

"It'll stimulate them!" Adora shrieks, turning up the volume just to piss Catra off and laughing in her face, "It's helping their development!"

"I'll develop you…" Catra growls and crawls over Adora's lap, stretching across her and snatching her phone triumphantly.

It isn't until she finds her favourite album that Catra notices she's sunk into Adora's lap, straddling her thighs. Adora's hands move to Catra's hips as her belly presses into Adora's muscled torso, fingers digging firmly into her flesh to keep her safely in place. Their faces are only inches away from each other and Catra can feel the shallow breeze of Adora's breath on her face. Catra marvels at how easy it would be to lean forward a couple of inches. Her whole body strains for it, palms tingling as she places them on Adora's shoulders. Adora's lips part - Catra wonders if it might actually be a sign Adora that reciprocates her desire - and Catra grinds her hips, moaning involuntarily at the sensation of Adora's firm thigh through her sleep shorts. Her heart seems to thump louder than it ever has before. Catra opens her eyes slowly and sees how Adora's irises are swallowed by black pools - she's hardly seconds away from closing the gap between them - but she's interrupted by a powerful kick. She can't stop a groan of pain from slipping through her lips and she knows they're pressed close enough that Adora has to have felt it too. Her hand flies off Adora and under her shirt to rub the spot her baby is kicking.

What am I doing?

Catra looks down at her bump and back up at Adora. The blonde's blue-grey eyes are full of care, and shame rises from Catra's gut like a river bursting through a dam. She can't bear it.

I can't do this to her. She needs someone without all this baggage, who isn't covered in stretchmarks like a fucking zebra. You'll ruin her life.

"I'm s-sorry," Catra stammers, scrambling away from Adora as quickly as she's able to manage, "It m-must be my hormones. I've

been horny for weeks."

It's not a total lie - Catra's morning showers have gotten significantly longer while she seeks to relieve the ache between her legs. Sometimes she's so needy there isn't any hot water left for Adora at all. She's too embarrassed to tell her why. Catra's washed her over-moisturised hair nearly every day just to have a convenient excuse.

"Catra!"

She hears Adora call after her as she charges down the hallway to the bedroom. The second the door slams shut behind her, Catra can tell she's going to implode. Her heart feels like it's ripping into pieces as she realises she can never have Adora. Catra's made it too complicated. She crawls into bed, her lungs clutching at air through her tears, and curls as best she can into a ball. Like they're trying to comfort her, her baby kicks hard against her insides again.

"It's just you and me, kiddo," Catra whimpers under her breath, "That's how it's supposed to be. How we wanted it."

Her pillow's already damp from crying, but Catra's so spent that she falls asleep anyway. When she wakes in the twilight, Adora's back where she usually is, their feet tangled together in the sheets.

The crowd's friendly but Adora grips Catra's hand in hers protectively as they move through the stadium, bending her body around Catra's whenever anyone gets too close for comfort. In the week since the almost-kiss - since Adora thought for a few short lived seconds that happily ever after could actually come true - Catra's been more tentative in her touch, often maintaining a

careful distance between them. Still, she hasn't banished Adora from her bed.

Today has almost felt normal between them again. Catra surprised her with tickets to the women's qualifiers for her birthday, and it's been months since Adora's seen a football match, let alone played in one. Adora had put her old personalised 'Grey' football shirt on and they'd shuffled into the stands with Glimmer and Bow, ready for adrenaline to rush through their veins. Now more than eight months pregnant, Catra ducks out for the loo three, maybe four, times in the two hours they're there. It gives Glimmer the opportunity to comment on how heavily pregnant Catra looks, and Adora's grateful she isn't there to hear it. She's seen Catra stare at herself in the mirror with narrowed eyes after she takes her weekly bump progress pictures, sighing when she catches sight of her old clothes in the wardrobe. It doesn't matter how many times Adora emphasises how beautiful she is - Catra fobs it off every time and jokes about how everyone *thinks* the miracle of life is beautiful until they learn better.

Adora catches sight of the bathroom as they approach the stadium exit. Everyone's high on the home win and singing at the top of their lungs so she has to shout into Catra's ear.

"Do you need to go again? Last chance before the pub!"

Before Catra can answer, Glimmer's loud voice somehow cuts over several rows of football fans between them.

"Hurry up, guys!" Glimmer shouts over her shoulder at them, blue war stripes now smudged on her cheeks, "Everywhere will get full if we're not quick enough!"

Adora glances down at Catra, watching as frustration clouds her features. Catra's slipped her arm inside her sleeve and has it draped over her stomach inside her coat; Adora can tell she's feeling vulnerable. She cuts through the crowd and guides them to the toilets, ignoring Glimmer in the background.

“You should go ahead,” Catra says when they join the bathroom queue, failing to hide the slight waver in her voice, “By the time I’m done, it’ll take forever to get to the pub.”

“Don’t be silly, it’ll be fine. Anyway, I need the loo too,” Adora lies through her teeth and washes her hands for the pretence when Catra disappears into a stall.

Catra takes forever - she always does these days - so Adora makes room for the growing toilet queue by slipping out. She waits facing the bathroom entrance, keen to make sure Catra finds her as soon as she comes out. It’s the right choice when Catra finally appears, a bashful smile on her face as she takes the hand Adora holds out.

“Adam? Is that you, Grey?” A familiar voice bleeds into Adora’s back. She’s sure it’s her old football coach from university - she’d recognise that gravelly tone anywhere.

Catra's face pales. It’s like watching her own soul freeze in real time. Adora turns slowly, trance-like. She hasn’t been deadnamed in over seven years.

“C-Coach Lashor?” Adora’s shocked she manages to say anything.

The older man flusters when he sees Adora properly and takes in the curves of her figure. “Sorry, love,” he feigns ignorance, but Adora can see clear recognition in his eyes, “Used to coach a lad about your height with a blonde ponytail.”

Catra steps out to Adora’s side, placing her free hand on Adora’s bicep. Coach Lashor’s line of sight settles on her, widening a little at her prominent bump.

“Congrats on the kid,” he says eventually, his voice betraying his discomfort, “They let all sorts happen these days, eh?”

Adora feels Catra’s worrisome gaze on her before she feels herself being pulled away. She thinks she doesn’t breathe until they’re

finally out of the stadium. She stumbles over to the stadium grounds, sinking onto the grass.

“Adora,” Catra comes into sight, her edges sharpening when Adora blinks away her tears, “Are you okay? I’m so sorry that happened.”

“I thought I passed,” Adora whispers, “I know it doesn’t make me any less of a… But I really thought I…”

“It *wouldn’t* make you any less of a woman,” Catra leans forward on her knees and interrupts Adora’s spiral, “But you do pass, princess. You know that.”

Adora blinks. When she looks at Catra, all she sees is the girl who hadn’t even glanced at her until third year, but who’d become her biggest supporter when she built up the confidence to come out. It’s impossible to quash the longing that sweeps through her in the moment. She’d purposefully ignored her hopes that Catra might finally be interested in her romantically once she’d transitioned, and now she’s seeing Catra’s body grow with her own child, it feels like she’s playing some kind of trick on herself. This is all she ever wanted - to have Catra and form a family. And now she’s going to spend the rest of her life wishing she had it for real.

“You’re the most incredible person, ‘Dor. You’re so caring and smart, and unbelievably compassionate. You’ll be the best aunt to my kid that they could possibly have. Just look at what you’ve done for me already,” Catra’s crying too now, and though she knows it doesn’t take much to set her off anymore, Adora still feels a little guilty, “Don’t let a dick like him make you see yourself any differently. Please.”

“I wish I’d done it for me too,” Adora mumbles.

Catra almost chokes on her own tears and it’s only then that Adora realises she’d spoken aloud, “What? Adora, I don’t understand what you're saying.”

"I… I don't think I want to be the baby's aunt, Cat," Adora trembles as she speaks, unable to meet Catra's eye, "I want to co-parent with you."

Catra stares at her, mouth agape.

Adora looks down at her lap, dread already setting into her bones. "I might never meet anyone. I don't know if I'll ever have another chance."

"This isn't what we agreed," Catra says after what seems like an age.

"I know. I didn't expect to feel this way, I promise," Adora forces herself to look up at Catra, "I just… I already love this baby so much, Catra. More than I thought possible."

Their eyes meet and Catra studies Adora's expression, taking in all her vulnerability.

"If we change the plan…" Catra speaks slowly, "If we decide to do this together, Adora, there's no going back. You're everything to me, but I won't let you fuck with my kid."

"I'd never do anything to hurt them, Cat," Adora promises, "I'm in this one hundred percent. Emotionally, financially. Everything."

Catra doesn't reply; she looks down at her stomach and frowns instead. Adora hopes she believes her, and that she hasn't ruined their friendship entirely.

"We'll have to figure out what they'll call us now," Catra says after a few minutes, "Aunt Adora clearly isn't going to cut it."

"Are you sure?" Adora squeaks, her throat tight.

"Not yet. But I will be," Catra inhales deeply, "There's a lot of reasons why I knew you'd be a good donor, and they're the same ones that'll make you an incredible parent. You'll keep them safe, won't you?"

“I’d die trying,” Adora vows.

“Preferably don’t do that,” Catra rolls her eyes and it reassures Adora that everything is genuinely alright between them again, “I’ve just found out I don’t have to be a single mother and I’m getting slightly attached to the idea.”

Catra sighs and motions for Adora to stand. “Come on. I’m going to need help getting up and Lord knows Glimmer will kill us if we take any longer.”

Adora pulls Catra to her feet, her hand automatically darting to her lower back when Catra grunts.

“Can we tell Glimmer and Bow when we find them? Or do you want to think about it.”

Catra shakes her head and leans into Adora’s shoulder as they begin to walk, “There’s no point hoarding good news. May as well, mum.”

Adora grins so hard that Catra calls her an idiot ten times on the way to the pub.

They settle back into a comfortable rhythm as Catra sails past the nine month mark of pregnancy. She hardly sleeps - which means Adora hardly sleeps - but solidarity builds between them now the dynamic of shared parenthood has come to the fore. Adora doesn’t have to bite back her thoughts on what equipment to buy for the baby anymore, or swallow her yearning when she watches Catra hand paint the crib with illustrations of tiny fish. For the final stretch of this pregnancy, she holds Catra’s belly in her hands and presses kisses to textured skin. Catra, for her own part, has gotten more comfortable asking for help. There’s no such thing as too many favours now she’s carrying for both of them.

“I wish they would hurry up and come,” Catra complains when Adora brings her a bowl of cereal on the first day of her fortieth week, “I’m going to be so pissed if they’re overdue.”

“They’ll come when they’re ready,” Adora reassures her, “Are you sure you don’t mind me going out for the day? I’ll cancel it if you want me to stay with you.”

Catra shakes her head definitively. No matter how many times Adora has said she’d rather be at home, both Catra and Glimmer are determined she goes on some stupid coffee date with a woman Glimmer met at a work conference. She doesn’t tell either of them how Catra’s enthusiasm disappoints her, though it is a relief to finally get Glimmer off her back.

“I don’t wanna hold you back, ‘Dor,” Catra insists, “I’ll call you if anything happens.”

As expected, the date’s a bust. Adora can’t stop checking her phone the entire time she’s out, thinking about Catra alone at home. It’s becoming harder to pretend that it isn’t Catra’s fault that Adora’s so uninterested in dating; her feelings for the brunette swell more every day. Sure, she’s been in love with Catra for most of her adult life, but now Adora’s fallen in love with the family they’re building too. Their life together is no longer a fantasy. When her date asks if she wants to extend their time together and grab dinner, Adora declines immediately. Something burns in her chest urgently, like fire spreading through her arteries. All she can think about is that she has to confess her feelings for Catra before the baby comes.

By the time she lets herself back into the flat, Adora’s fully trembling in anticipation.

Her heartbeat accelerates as she approaches the living room but Catra’s nowhere to be found when she gets there. Her ears prickle at the soothing music that’s been left playing in the lounge, and then she notices a broken comb on the coffee table. She’d bought that comb for Catra to squeeze during contractions on the advice

of their midwife, and the music is unmistakably the playlist they've used when practising Catra's hypnobirthing techniques.

Is Catra in labour already?

Adora rushes through the flat as she calls out Catra's name, and kicks every door open until she finds Catra in the bathroom. She's sitting backwards on the toilet, her forehead draped over her arms on the back of the cistern. As soon as Adora reaches her, running a hand up her shirt to rub circles on her back, Catra lets out a groan unlike anything Adora's heard before.

"Catra?" Adora speaks as calmly as possible when the contraction seems to have subsided and Catra's body relaxes under her palm, "Why didn't you call me?"

Catra whimpers, "I left my phone in the kitchen by accident after I called the midwife. She said I was definitively in labour."

"I think that's kind of obvious," Adora retorts, "Let me grab your hospital bag and put it in the car. We'll go as soon as your water breaks, hmm?"

"It broke already," Catra whispers, her eyes flitting to the bathroom clock, "Nearly three hours ago."

" *Three* hours-?"

Adora doesn't get the chance to berate her - an even deeper moan ripples through Catra's body and bleeds loudly out of her throat.

"God, Adora. It hurts so much!" Catra sobs, "I don't know why I thought that hypnobirthing bullshit was going to do anything!"

"It's okay," Adora kisses Catra's forehead, "You're doing so well."

"I'm not doing well!" Catra screeches at her, "I knew when my water broke that I should leave but I was too scared to go by myself!" Catra weeps even louder and Adora feels at a total loss of

what to do, "The baby isn't even born yet and I'm already fucking everything up."

"You haven't fucked up anything, Catra," Adora says firmly, "I'm going to get the hospital bag and some leggings for you and we'll go to the hospital now, okay?"

Catra nods, her entire body shaking. She tries to stand, her oversized t-shirt falling past her thighs as she rises, but her legs wobble so badly that Adora rushes to help her walk to the kitchen and drink some water. They don't even get halfway down the hallway before Catra doubles over again and cries out, her fingers digging into Adora's arm so hard that she's guaranteed to bruise.

That can't be more than a few minutes between, Adora calculates mentally, *t his is actually happening!*

Adora feels like she's caught in a whirlwind as she races to the bedroom to get everything they need, but she isn't prepared for the fearful look on Catra's face when she gets back to the kitchen, or for the dialling tone that's ringing out on the loudspeaker of her phone. Adora's mind races.

Is she calling for an ambulance?

"I don't think I can get in the car, 'Dor," Catra's forehead glistens, the kitchen spotlights bouncing off the sweat there and the tears that have started rolling down her cheeks, "I don't think I'll even make it to the lift."

Adora's paralysed, hardly able to comprehend what Catra's said until another surge of pain hits her. She can hardly bear to see how much Catra is suffering. This is all her fault. If she hadn't offered to help, Catra wouldn't be going through this at all.

She's knocked out of her thoughts when Catra starts to sink to the floor, accidentally pulling a tea towel from the drying rack with her. Adora grabs Catra sideways before she can fall, grabbing the mobile phone off the counter as soon as she's safe on the floor.

“Nine-nine-nine, what’s your emergency?” The operator’s voice echoes on the kitchen tiles..

“The b-baby’s coming,” Adora stammers, “I think it’s too late for us to come in.”

“It’s definitely too late,” Catra grunts with effort, “Fuck… I need…”

Adora’s eyes widen when Catra’s next contraction takes over her and cuts off her speech. She knows that if Catra can’t talk through it that she has to be close to birthing. She rattles off their names and address information to the emergency operator, but there’s hardly time to put the phone on the floor before Catra grabs at Adora and pulls herself up so she’s kneeling, her arms looped around Adora’s neck. Adora can feel her straining, vibrations pushing against her throat with extreme effort.

“Catra, are you-?”

Catra’s cry is more than enough for Adora to figure out what’s happening. This is the birthing position they’d discussed with Catra’s midwife, and it’s obvious that Catra’s bearing down already. She’s gone almost entirely silent, all her effort funnelled into pushing.

“She’s pushing,” Adora shrieks helplessly at the phone, “How close is the ambulance? I don’t know what I’m doing, and I-”

“Adora?” The operator interrupts Adora’s panicked ramble, “You have to stay calm for Catra, alright? When her next contraction ends, I need you to check if you can see the baby’s head.”

“Don’t make me move,” Catra begs when the operator finishes speaking and Adora tries to ease Catra onto her back, “Just… Feel for them instead. Please.”

Adora complies, snaking her hand under the hem of Catra’s sodden t-shirt and feeling between her legs. Catra shifts her weight even further onto Adora. It’s a miracle she can do anything

at all; Adora gasps when she feels a soft bulge meet her fingertips.

“You’re crowning, Catra.”

Catra lets out a whine, her eyes wildly unfocused. She swats Adora’s hand out the way with her own and feels for herself.

“No, no… ‘Dor. I’m not ready. I can’t do this.” Catra is becoming more panicked by the second.

“You’re already doing it,” Adora reassures her, awe seeping into every word, “You’ve done so well already. You’ve got this.”

“Catra, I want you to listen to your body when you next feel the need to push,” The operator’s so authoritative that Catra nods vigorously even though she can’t be seen, “Adora’s going to count to ten when you start and then you’ll rest between, okay?”

Adora starts to count as soon as Catra’s fists begin to twist into the fabric of Adora’s shirt, but they don’t even reach six before Adora can feel the weight of their baby’s head in her hands.

“The head’s out!” Adora announces in shock, as much for her own benefit as anyone else’s.

They’re instructed that Catra should rest for a couple of minutes, though it’s only a few seconds before Catra’s already pushing again, groaning gutturally until she gasps with relief. Adora catches a tiny, slippery body from under her with shaking hands. There’s a sharp cry - it’s more akin to a mewl - and Catra’s face crumples as she takes the baby from Adora into her arms.

“Hi,” Catra cries as she ghosts her palm over the baby’s head, leaning forwards into Adora’s embrace, “They’re here, Adora. They made it.”

“You did it, Catra.” Adora kisses Catra’s cheek, marvelling at the writhing babe between them. She has no idea how Catra

managed this, how this child has managed to make its way into the world so chaotically.

Figures, Adora laughs to herself, *Catra's the most dramatic person I know. Of course our kid's going to follow in her footsteps.*

Catra gazes down at her baby as they suckle on her breast. It's been two exhausting weeks of Finn - of non-stop nappies, and breastfeeding, and vomit dribbling down her back - but she's never been more sure of any decision she's ever made. When she looks up, she sees Adora leaning against the frame of their bedroom door with a baby blanket folded over her shoulder, a dreamy smile painted on her face.

"What are you looking at?" Catra teases, though she's caught Adora with this expression several times a day since she gave birth.

"My family," Adora replies simply and Catra's heart warms.

She beckons the blonde over and shuffles so that Adora can join them in bed, nestling her back into Adora's chest. Adora's arm comes up instinctively to support Catra's elbow under Finn's head, and the release of tension feels so good that Catra could cry all over again - though really, when did she stop?

I've got more than I ever thought possible. So what if she doesn't love me the same way?

Adora hums next to Catra's ear as Finn's hand grabs at her long curls; Adora slips her finger into their palm instead and they clamp around it tightly.

"Can you believe they weren't here sixteen days ago?" Catra breathes out, her mind circling back to the absurdity of Finn's

birth, “I’m so grateful you got home when you did.”

“About that…’ Adora’s voice sounds suddenly unsure, and Catra can feel her heartbeat speeding up from behind, “My date wanted to spend longer, but I realised I had to come home right away and tell you…”

“What?” Catra whispers. She doesn’t really want to hear about Adora’s dating prospects, even though she’d promised Glimmer that she’d help Adora get out there more.

“Isn’t it obvious?” Adora asks, “Catra, I’ve been completely in love with you forever.”

Immediately, the world stops turning. There’s nothing Catra can see or feel but the strength of Finn’s latch and the bristle of Adora’s golden hair spilling onto her shoulder.

“It’s fine if you don’t feel the same way,” Adora continues cautiously, “Nothing has to change between us, or with Finn. I just couldn’t live without telling you any longer.”

Catra doesn’t know how to respond. There’s four words waiting to be voiced on the tip of her tongue but nothing feels *enough* to capture the weight of her feeling, how rolling waves of pleasure and relief crash over her heart in tandem.

“Catra?” Adora sounds nervous now, “I know it’s a lot. Do you need me to give you some space?”

That snaps her out of it. In seconds, she’s tugging Adora’s face towards her own, chasing the pillowy softness of her lips. Momentarily, Adora freezes in place, before she deepens the kiss with fervour; Catra can feel every ounce of her longing and desire, so exactly the same as the emotion she’s pouring back into Adora.

“I love you too. I always have,” Catra sighs, her forehead dropping under Adora’s chin, “Stay.”

“Are you sure? I won’t be offended.”

Catra can’t help but laugh as she tips her head backwards to press her lips to the blonde’s jaw. “Adora, you’re such an idiot.”

I never want to let you go.

Adora balances Finn in her lap, squeezing the two-year-old as she looks around the ceremonial hall. It’s much grander than she ever expected - certainly far fancier than the venue she and Catra had when they graduated the first time - but it’s exactly what she thinks Catra deserves.

“Are you ready to cheer for Mama, Finny?” Adora asks them, grinning when they nod their head enthusiastically.

“How many times are you going to ask them that?” Glimmer teases, “Poor kid’s going to think it’s Groundhog Day.”

“I’d be perfectly happy if they remember this day for the rest of their lives, Glim.”

It’s easy for Adora to rebuke her friend; Glimmer and Bow are just as proud as she is. It’s more than obvious in the way they’ve been quizzing Adora for weeks to figure out exactly what food - from the side dips to the triple-layer-cake - that Catra would want at the surprise party they’ve planned.

When the roll call starts and Finn catches sight of Catra waiting at the side of the stage, they immediately erupt into eager chatter, clapping their hands together. By the time Catra actually climbs the stairs and walks on, Finn’s standing on Adora’s knees and she has to hold onto their hips to help them balance.

“That’s my wife!” Adora hollers when Catra collects her solicitor’s qualification certificate, peeking round her kid to see Catra roll her eyes fondly.

“Tha’s Mama!” Finn mimics her and the entire auditorium laughs and coos at their excitement. Catra breaks out into the widest smile Adora’s seen since she got the results of her exams.

Later, when their bellies are full of cake and Prosecco, and Finn falls asleep in Catra’s arms on the sofa, Adora plants a kiss on the side of her wife’s head.

“This is all I ever wanted,” she murmurs, “I’m so proud of you.”

“You’re such a sap,” Catra replies affectionately and turns her head to kiss Adora on the lips, lingering for several long seconds after, “I should have known everything would work out in the end. It's destiny.”

Adora gazes at Catra before tousling her fingers in Finn’s blonde curls, smiling at the haze of contentment spreading through her. There’s nothing left she can say but agree.

End Notes

Thank you for reading! I hope this scratched any brainrot itches of yours too :)

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